

# St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 11, Jan 19/ Feb 1 2021

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Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter on at least the first and the 15<sup>th</sup> of each month. This is the 11<sup>th</sup> sent to 78 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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**NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need anything.**

## Questions about The Meeting of the Lord

**This is a quiz! Don't cheat! Really! Read the Gospel account, (Luke 2:22-38), and try to answer the questions, THEN look at the answers. The homily will help you answer the questions. Do it! Do it now! The answers are at the end of the newsletter.**

1. Describe the feast of the Meeting of the Lord. What is being commemorated?
2. Why did Jesus follow the Jewish law?
3. Why is the Meeting of the Lord February 2 (on the church calendar)? To answer this question you must know the requirements of the Jewish law regarding when a child was brought to the temple and a sacrifice was made.
4. Why was Simeon waiting to see the Messiah? There is a very edifying tradition regarding him. Do you know it?
5. When is the song of Simeon used in our prayer services?
6. The song of Simeon is not only a prayer of praise and thanksgiving from a man who would have been waiting a long time to see the Savior, but it is also a prophecy. Of what?
7. The Song of Simeon speaks about: "mine eyes have seen thy salvation." What does it mean to "see" the salvation of the Lord? Simeon was speaking literally because he was literally looking at Jesus Christ when

he said this prayer however, we say it every day. What do we mean by seeing the salvation of the Lord since obviously we do not look at Him with our eyes? Think of the verb "to see" as a metaphor. I know this is not a well-defined question, but living the Christian life is often not well defined in absolute particulars. We learn basic things and follow them, and the wisdom of God shows us the way.

8. What was the reason that the law required a sacrifice on the 40<sup>th</sup> day after childbirth? Do we have any requirement like that?

9. Simeon made three explicit prophecies: "And Simeon blessed them, and said unto Mary his mother, (1a) Behold, this child is set for the fall and rising again of many in Israel; and (1b) for a sign which shall be spoken against; (2) (Yea, a sword shall pierce through thy own soul also,) (3) that the thoughts of many hearts may be revealed." (Luke 2:34-35)

Please explain each one, that is the prophecies following the numbers in the text above: (1a), (1b), (2), (3). This takes a little thinking, but you can do it if you try.

10. The Evangelists were individuals and individuals don't always tell

the story exactly the same. They emphasize different things. St. Luke leaves out an event that probably happened almost immediately after the Meeting. He just informs us that: "And when they had performed all things according to the law of the Lord, they returned into Galilee, to their own city Nazareth. And the child grew, and waxed strong in spirit, filled with

wisdom: and the grace of God was upon Him. (Luke 2:39-40) What event did St Luke leave out?

11. Bonus question! Luke tells us regarding Symeon: "And he came by the Spirit into the temple." Explain what he means by the words "by the Spirit."

## The Meeting of the Lord: The Song of Symeon must be our song at the end. Feb 2/15

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, amen. The Meeting of the Lord is described only by the Apostle Luke, and he presents to us two fascinating personalities from whom we can learn very much, Symeon, the God-Receiver, and Anna the Prophetess.

Our Lord Jesus Christ is the creator of the law and the fulfillment of the law, and since He was born as a Jew subject to the law, He obeyed the law. Jewish law required that a first-born male be brought to the temple on the 40<sup>th</sup> day in a sacrifice be made. As an obedient Jew, Jesus Christ obeyed the law and was brought to the temple by his parents, and the sacrifice was made. The sacrifice was an acknowledgment that we are born in sin, not that sexual intercourse is sinful, but that how humans are propagated is different now than it would've been if there had been no sin. However, Jesus was conceived in a different way than all of humanity and born in a miraculous way also. He was not conceived in sin nor born in sin, but He chose to obey the law because he was born as a Jewish male subject to the law.

Symeon was a man who, according to tradition, had been involved in the translation of the Septuagint (a Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures, which the Orthodox Church considers to be the authoritative translation, and which was used extensively in Jesus time because most of the Jews of the Diaspora did not speak Hebrew well. The translation occurred sometime in the third century BC.). He was translating the part of Isaiah which said, "Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel." (Is 7:14) That didn't make sense to Symeon, and he wanted to replace the word that meant "maiden, virgin" with the word that meant "married woman." He was rebuked by an angel and told to use the word "virgin" and that he would be alive until he saw that Messiah, and so he lived. Symeon was waiting for perhaps 300 years and was a very old man.

On that day that the Lord came to the temple, Symeon also came, as Luke says, "by the Holy Spirit." Upon seeing the infant Jesus Christ, he authored that prayer that we say so often, especially in every Vespers: "Now lettest Thou Thy *slave* depart in peace, O Master, according to Thy word, for mine eyes have seen Thy salvation, which Thou hast prepared before the face of all peoples; a light of revelation for the gentiles, and the glory of Thy people Israel."

The word used in the prayer is "*slave*." We don't like to say "slave," we prefer the "nicer" word "servant." Of course, men enslaving other men is a terrible institution. Some people are offended by the word "*slave*," but if you are a slave to a king who knows all that is good for you and is always good toward you, that is not slavery; it is true freedom. We should not be afraid to call ourselves slaves of God.

Symeon said this beautiful prayer because he was waiting for the Messiah to come, and he held the Messiah in his arms, and then he knew

that his days were done, that his work was finished. When I hear this prayer (I can't say all the time because sometimes I don't think I pay enough attention, but often enough when I hear this prayer), I think of my life and the lives of my loved ones, the lives of my flock, the lives of people that I touch. Will they say this at the end of their life? Will we say: 'Now lettest Thy slave depart *in peace*, O Master, according to Thy word?' Will we have lived our life well? Will we be at peace with God, with the world, with ourselves?

Symeon was entirely at peace. He had fulfilled the Lord's command, and therefore he knew it was time for him to depart. I wonder about that. I'm so busy living right now, so busy doing so many things, getting up early, and going here and going there, doing this and doing that, but in the midst of all that, I wonder often will I say that prayer of Symeon with full conviction when it's time for me to die. Will you be able to say this prayer: "Now lettest Thou Thy slave depart in peace, according to Thy word?"

The whole point of our life is to have peace. Are we obtaining it now? Right now, the world is a very un-peaceful place, and I'm an un-peaceful person in it, but I'm struggling to have peace, and I hope that you are too, so that you can say this prayer of Symeon with full conviction and holiness. This is the point of our life - to be able to say this prayer with conviction: "Now lettest Thou, Thy slave, depart in peace."

Anna was an old woman, over 100 (Do the math: She was married 7 years, a widow for 84 years, and probably married in her teens. Therefore 15+7+84=105), and she lived only for God. She lived in the temple, and served God night and day, and waited for the coming of the Messiah. She rebukes me with her single-mindedness regarding God. I should be doing that too; you should be doing that also. This doesn't mean we have to be in the temple all day. We could still be doing the things we need to do in our daily lives, but with what kind of vigor, with what kind of love do we live our lives? She was committed entirely to God, and God rewarded her by allowing her to see the Messiah before she died.

Symeon and Anna rebuke us, but they also give us great hope because Symeon waited a long time. Anna also waited a long time, although not quite as long as Symeon. Because they are human, there must have been times when they were tired of waiting, when the days stretched into years and the years into decades. Is it ever like that with you? Do you ever have things you're tired of waiting for, or perhaps just tired of dealing with? I have them all the time. I know what I should do, and I might even keep on doing it, but I'm tired and weary. I think that tiredness and weariness sometimes is not just part of human nature to get tired, but also mixed with the sin of unbelief, of impatience.

I am waiting for many things. I am waiting for peace in my heart. I'm waiting for my whole family to be in the Kingdom. I'm waiting for my flock, every single one of you, to be intimately united with God. I'm waiting for people that have drug problems or psychological problems to be healed of their diseases. I'm waiting for the world not to be insane and on fire. I hope you are waiting for many things also.

It gets hard to wait, but Simeon waited, and so when I read this, I feel a little stronger. I can keep waiting. Sometimes it's hard, but it was hard for Simeon too, and Simeon was rewarded at the end of his long wait.

And so I believe it will be with me, although I'm a sinner. God knows that I try. I hope that you feel the same way about yourself. Although you are a sinner, you have confidence that God knows you try, and therefore you wait, and therefore God will reward you with seeing His salvation.

Let's learn in this meeting of the Lord from these two exemplary people, Simeon and Anna. Let's learn to be patient. Let's learn to be more single-minded about God, not to be so distracted with worldly things. Let's also learn to expect, *to be sure*, that God will reward us. May God help us in all things. Amen. (Priest Seraphim) <http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/feasts-of-the-theotokos-2014-02-15+meeting-of-the-lord+the-song-of-symeon-anna-the-prophetess.doc> This homily was transcribed, and then edited, from the audio: <http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/feasts-of-the-theotokos-2014-02-15+meeting-of-the-lord+the-song-of-symeon-anna-the-prophetess.mp3>

## A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 36-40

36. Melancholy and a troubled spirit result from insufficient prayer.

37. Call upon your Guardian Angel everywhere and always. (*Each one of us was blessed with one, from God, during our baptism.*)

38. Ever lament in your heart for your sins. When you have occasion to confess them and partake of the Holy Mysteries of Christ, rejoice in silence, and you will be cleansed.

39. Concern yourself only with your own inadequacies and imperfections. Guard yourself against dwelling on the sins of others and on passing judgment. Do not bring about your own perdition by judging others. He who judges others is an antichrist.

40. Do not trust even your good inclinations. Do not trust your own heart; instead, refer to the judgment of your spiritual Father. (*A humble 20th Century Russian monk always said: "Don't trust yourself this side of the grave!"*)

## Prison Ministry News

We have formed an unincorporated, non-profit association called "Saint Joseph the All-Comely Prison Ministry." Fr Seraphim will be the President, Fr David the Secretary, and a layman, Zoticus, will be the treasurer. With this association, we will purchase the building and land in Marshall. The next step after that is good people to live there!

As we said in the previous letter, we are starting small. We hope to have one or more stable people living there permanently and take one parolee at a time. We have plans to build other buildings. We are kind of making this up as we go along, so we would appreciate your prayers.

## Questions and Answers

### How to respond to someone insulting you and trying to pick a fight

You asked how to respond to someone insulting you and trying to pick a fight, and whether you should fight back: I don't say that you can't defend yourself if physically attacked; however, any forceful action should be motivated by a desire to restrain the other from evil, not to harm him. If, may God grant, you have the courage and contrition to bear an insult or attack without responding in like manner - setting before you the image of Christ Who was beaten and crucified for your sake - you will be in good company among the confessors for Christ.

Ultimately, resolving any conflict in a Christian manner requires humility and discernment, which God grants through prayer. If someone is name calling or urging you to fight, you should immediately pray the Jesus Prayer mentally. This sounds simplistic, but it's directly to the point.

The "atmosphere of hades" radiates from the heart that is not filled with the remembrance and Name of God but instead with earthly passions and cares (Elder Thaddeus speaks of this in "Our Thoughts Determine Our Lives"). This atmosphere consists of the fear, judgment, vengefulness, and anger you feel toward the one offending you- all of which passions will worsen the conflict. Call upon God - for yourself and the other person - praying, "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on us!" - and you begin to radiate the atmosphere of heaven: trust in God, humility, forgiveness, and the neighborly love of the Good Samaritan.

Maintaining outward silence is best, but if your neighbor persistently urges you to answer or speak, respond with simplicity and not by justifying yourself. If someone says, "You're an idiot" (yes, they'll say much worse than that), you might respond with a bit of good humor: "You may be right!" Don't try to please anyone, and don't fear anyone- only our all-good God and His righteous judgment.

Here is a story from the Desert Fathers that may illumine our understanding: Once, monks who had heard of his discernment came to Saint Agathon to see if they could make him lose his temper. They asked him, "Are you Abba Agathon, a fornicator and a proud man?" "Yes, that is true," the monk replied. "Are you the Agathon who is always talking nonsense?," the monks inquired. "I am," the saint agreed. "Are you Agathon the heretic?," the monks persisted. Saint Agathon said, "I am not a heretic." They asked the saint why he agreed with them when they accused him of vices, but then denied this last charge. Agathon replied, "I accepted the first accusations, since that was beneficial for my soul. But heresy is separation from God, and I do not wish to be separated from God." Astonished at his discernment, they returned to their monastery, edified. (Priest David)

### How to think about other Christian expressions

In Orthodox faith and practice, the focus is not on "how we differ from the Catholics and Protestants and where they've gone wrong" - though this may seem to be a theme, due to the number of questions we prison ministry priests receive about how to conduct oneself as an Orthodox Christian in association with the non-Orthodox - but instead, "what is so

good, true, and beautiful about the Orthodox Church, the Body of Christ, wherein the mystery of salvation and communion with the Holy Trinity is fully revealed”.

When the soul is married to Christ in the Church through baptism and chrismation, and receives of Him the gift of the Holy Spirit, she no longer desires to live in another household or to spend most of her time with neighbors outside the home; instead, she longs always to be in the loving presence and care of her Bridegroom: to be taught of Him, nourished by Him, communing with Him and our Heavenly Father in the Holy Spirit. The Orthodox Church is that royally adorned Body, sanctified temple, and holy community of God’s people where He dwells among men, and we strive always to enter more deeply into the knowledge and love of God within the peace and safety of the Church. From here, equipped for every good work, we go out to love our neighbor and share the faith.

Is there goodness, truth, and beauty to be found outside of the Orthodox Church, and especially in the confessions and communities of non-Orthodox Christians? (Such as Kairos, the Roman Catholic Church, etc.) Certainly there is, as I myself experienced during my years as a Protestant, and continue to experience in my interactions with the non-Orthodox in the world around me.

I would liken these other Christian confessions, however, to a table laden with food, on which some of the dishes are good and nourishing, but others are stale, poorly made, or polluted by something poisonous; one has to pick and choose, eating some and avoiding others, and thus the atmosphere is tinged with anxiety and suspicion: that is, in their teachings on God and salvation, there is both good and bad, true and false. The Orthodox Church, and the fullness of her Apostolic Faith, Succession, and Tradition, is instead the banquet table laden with only those good and wholesome foods, the eating of which brings the soul and body to health and vitality, enabling those who partake in faith and humility to know and to do the will of God. Most of all, she possesses the Sacraments of God, grace-filled and effectual for salvation. When presented with these two tables, the soul which desires life inclines toward the one where every good is found, where every enjoyment can be had without fear or doubt. (Priest David)

### The Orthodox view of salvation.

*“My question is this: Protestants believe man is doomed to judgment, and Jesus reconciled us. The Roman Catholics believe in original sin, Jesus as a sacrifice, and good works by people get us saved. What does the Orthodox say on these issues?”*

Forgive my laziness. I’ve written about this subject before, and sometimes it’s easier not to reinvent the wheel. Priest Seraphim

In Orthodoxy, we stress holiness above everything. God is holy. God made us to become holy, not just to save us. When I was Protestant, it was about being saved; it was about a contract with God. Now, it was a benevolent contract; God wants to save us, and so He saves us because of this thing that we do, where we ask Jesus to come into our heart, and therefore we are saved from being judged for our sin. In Orthodoxy, that’s not how we describe salvation. We describe it as the perfection of the soul in union with God, and how can you have those things without holiness? Therefore, Orthodoxy has a beautiful emphasis on holiness. (from [http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/theotokos\\_2019+dormition+holiness-definition-of-salvation\\_luke1-39-49,56.doc](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/theotokos_2019+dormition+holiness-definition-of-salvation_luke1-39-49,56.doc))

The whole idea of Salvation is different in the Orthodox Church. It is the same word, but a much different meaning. The Roman Catholics and most Protestants believe in salvation as basically being saved from God’s wrath. They believe that God is completely holy and cannot tolerate any sin in His presence. The first statement is, of course, true, but the second is not. We are still alive, and evil men have lived long lives, and God is everywhere, so He will certainly tolerate sin in His presence. The one who cannot tolerate sin in God’s presence is us. Our sin makes us ashamed, and we cannot bear to be in the presence of God because of His holiness. This is a terrible problem that was solved by the incarnation and our reaction to it. The way we understand the solution is not the same as the typical Roman Catholic and Protestant understanding, given below.

According to the relatively new doctrine, called by some the “substitutionary atonement,” since we are sinful, and He is infinitely good, there must be an infinite sacrifice so that He will tolerate us and we will be saved. Jesus Christ became a man so that he could take on the infinite punishment that was required by sin, and then God would tolerate our presence since we would be forgiven and holy.

This is not what Orthodox Christians think. God loves us and has loved us and will love us, whether we love Him or not. He never changes his mind. The sacrifice of Jesus Christ on the cross did not change God’s mind. That sacrifice, of a perfect man without sin dying the death that sin inevitably requires, caused *us to be able to change our minds* and the strength to carry through our resolve. Through baptism, we partake of the sacrifice of Jesus Christ on the cross, and we give ourselves over to Him, and we begin the path of perfection. God does not require our perfection for Him to accept us. He does not make a decree that we are perfect. He gives us grace so that through struggle, we can become perfected. This grace is especially apparent in baptism, but of course, God’s grace is always present for all men, whether they be believers or not believers. Baptism changes us so that we can take in His grace and keep Him in our hearts. The apostle Paul characterizes this change as becoming a “new creature.” (from [http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/prison-ministry-visits\\_2018-02-14+participation-in-divine-liturgy-intercommunion-salvation-sign-of-the-cross-slaves.doc](http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/prison-ministry-visits_2018-02-14+participation-in-divine-liturgy-intercommunion-salvation-sign-of-the-cross-slaves.doc))

See also the Sermon (given 1/31/2021), below.

The Rich Young Ruler asked the wrong question!

Salvation is becoming good through the grace of the One Who is Good.

Luke 18:18-27



In the Name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, Amen.

You must ask the right questions! If you don't ask the right questions, you will never get the right answers. The fundamental question regarding us, is of course: "Who are you?" God made man, and God created man to know God, and that's the answer, that's who you are. You are made in the image of God to know God<sup>1</sup>.

The question that this young man asked was not a good question. Some of the Fathers think he was trying to trick the Lord, to get Jesus to say something that would be against the law, to condemn Him. Others felt that he was sincere in his question because, in St. Mark, it says: "Jesus, beholding him loved him."<sup>2</sup> It could be that it was a sincere question, or a capricious question. Regardless, it was the wrong question.

The Scripture calls this man a "certain ruler," meaning that he was a synagogue ruler, a teacher. He was a person who knew the law. He was a person who supposedly would tell other people the things of salvation. Nevertheless, he asks an ignorant question: "Good teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"

Jesus immediately exposes to him that this is the wrong question. He says, "why you call me good, only God is good?" He thought of Jesus as a teacher, and he called Him "good." But goodness does not come from a teacher. Goodness does not come from another man. Goodness does not come from a system of beliefs. Goodness comes from God; all goodness is from God. Only God is good. The Scripture says, "God is good;"<sup>3</sup> man is not good by nature. Nothing is good by nature except God. God is wholly good with no evil in Him whatsoever, with no, shall we say, badness in Him.

In His love, God reaches out to man, and man, if he listens and has a heart that is appropriately disposed, is changed by this love, and he becomes good. In steps. Not all at once. Whereas God is always good and never ceases from being good, man can sometimes do good and sometimes bad things, even in the same moment. Sometimes he can do a good thing with a bad motive. Sometimes he can try to do a bad thing which turns out to be good because God can do anything He wishes. God allows us to do what we would, but if we do the things that lead to being good, He will help those things, and we will become good.

The teacher did not understand Who he was talking to and didn't understand he should not have asked about a *thing*. This is not how Christianity is; it is not things we must do so. The Lord first talks about things we must do to show this man, "not only are you calling me good, and you don't even know that all good is from God only, but also you don't even know how to become good because you think of it as of the list of steps to do, discrete steps such as the commandments. So, I'll go ahead and tell you the commandments; you know them: 'don't commit adultery, don't kill, don't steal don't bear false witness, and honor your father and your mother.'"

The ruler responds: "I kept all these," and he did, but only in a superficial way. If any of us look carefully, can we ever say that we've never committed adultery? If you even look after a woman to lust after, you committed adultery. Can we say that we never killed? Isn't hatred and slandering a kind of killing? Morally it is. We really can't claim that we are



innocent of any of these things, but in the big picture, we can say, we have not committed adultery; we have not killed, we have not robbed any banks.

The Lord knows what this man needs. It is not to do a discrete group of things. None of us need to do a particular group of things to be saved, certain works to be saved. We need to be good. We need to become good. We need to change so that we are like our Lord Jesus Christ. We are already made in His image, and we are to obtain His likeness so that we can be good, truly good. We will not be likely to completely achieve this in our temporal life. Maybe there will still be some darkness in us in this life, but we are to become good, not just to do or not do stuff, but to attain the likeness of God.

The Lord says this man: "sell everything you have and distribute to the poor and come and follow me," because He knew this man was attached to his riches and he would do everything religious except give away all of his wealth. That was the impediment for this man. And he couldn't do it, so he went away sorrowful because he wanted Jesus to give him a list of things to do (except, of course, the one thing that He did tell him to do!).

In college, I loved my classes; I loved learning things. Most people just wanted to be able to get a good grade on the test. As a test would be coming up, they would ask the professor: "we didn't have any lectures on material from chapters 7 and 8. Will that be on the test?" They didn't want to study chapters that were not going to be tested. Usually, the professor would be upset and say that everything the class was told to read and had been lectured was testable.

I always thought this was such a minimalist way of looking at life. A lot of times, Christians take this kind of view. Often, people have an attitude that if a loved one dies, they will come light a candle, and that's enough. And then they will forget about their loved one until the next year.

That's a minimalist way of looking at things. That's a way of saying, "what *thing* should I do?" It's not "*what* you should do," it's "*who* you should be."

I recently had a letter from someone in prison. We have a custom in our newsletter of answering questions. A question was asked about salvation: "*Protestants believe man is doomed to judgment, and Jesus reconciled us. The Roman Catholics believe in original sin, Jesus as a sacrifice, and good works by people get us saved. What does Orthodoxy say on these issues?*" The contents of this sermon are the answer to that question.

"How are you saved" is to become good. That's precisely how you are saved: by the grace of God living in you, and you react to this grace. With God's grace, you love your fellow man, especially the one that's not so lovely, and you forgive people, and you humble yourself, and you see people with a need and reach out to them. In whatever way you can, you might reach out to them, either with your hands or with your feet, or with your money, or with your time, or maybe just with a good word or with prayer with a prostration.

Salvation is to *become like Jesus Christ*. He became man to show us the way, and He lived a perfect human life and showed us that we could live a perfect human life, and He gave us an entrance to a perfect human life through baptism, and then with the grace of God helping us, and with our struggle, doing things to be sure, we become good.

Salvation is union with God because we are good. I think you've had this experience before, where you have been around someone calmer than you or more humble or kinder, and you didn't understand how they could be so calm, or humble, or kind. Hopefully, you had a sort of holy jealousy, thinking, "I wish I could be like that." If you're not calm, you cannot understand why a person would be calm; if you're not kind, you cannot understand kindness. So, if you're not good, you cannot understand goodness, and goodness is God, pure goodness with nothing added or taken away, only goodness. That's what God is, and we are born to be that, so salvation is to become good.

The path begins with baptism, and then many re-baptisms, not in water, re-baptism in repentance. After one baptism with water, thousands upon thousands, millions of re-baptisms with repentance. We repent when we recognize that we did something wrong. Usually, it's not as much something we did as something *we are*, something in our heart that's not right, that is dark. And when we recognize that, hopefully, we will be filled with good, godly shame, which moves us to good, godly repentance, and then cleansing and then becoming good, or at least becoming better. That's the whole point. The whole point of our life is to become good since we cannot know the one Who is good until we have become like Him.

That's why we emphasize religious things that we do, such as fasting and the following of the commandments. They are not works to do to obtain salvation. They are things that will shape us and make us capable of receiving God. Fasting is the opposite of selfishness, and gluttony, and of thinking primarily of ourselves. Fasting teaches us to think like God. When we think like God, then God fills us with Himself; we are living as God. The Psalm says, "ye are gods<sup>4</sup>"; this is describing salvation. We are to become like God.

People love to have things defined. A popular doctrine of salvation is a definition. Jesus came down from heaven, and He was crucified because we deserve to die. His Father found a suitable victim that would give an eternal sacrifice. And now you're all saved, but you're not good - all that happens in this doctrine is a legal declaration that you're no longer to be judged, and nothing about who you become or how.

That's not what happened on the cross! On the cross, Jesus Christ destroyed the power of sin and death. He didn't go to the cross as a *victim*. He went to the cross as a *conqueror*, and He conquered sin and death on the cross, and now we can conquer sin and death because He lives within us, and we can become perfected.

Salvation is *not well defined*! Relationships are not defined; they are experienced and lived. What is the definition of your relationship with your mother and father? Can you define it? No. They love you. Sometimes you get on their nerves; sometimes, they punish you. Sometimes because we are human, we have words with each other. But we know that we have a relationship. We can't define that relationship. It just is, and we *know* it because we *experience* it.

And that's what salvation is, an experience of God in a relationship. We are not able to fully experience Him because we are too weak. We have too many other things going on, too many things that are not like God, and the things in our heart that are not like God confuse us, and put shades over our eyes and cotton in our ears, and we cannot hear or see God clearly, because of our sins. But as our sins begin to fall off of us through our effort and God's mercy, through the sacraments of the church, fasting, through prayer and prostrations, through all these things guided by the Holy Spirit, as the sins start to fall away, we see God more clearly, no longer in a glass darkly, but face-to-face<sup>5</sup>. That is salvation: to see God face-to-face, and you recognize Him!

Why do we recognize someone? Because they are like us in some way. We can recognize a human being immediately. We can see a figure somewhere far away, and know that the way that the figure moves, it is a human being; it is not a cat or a monkey. We can tell. How do we know? Because we are human beings. How many times do we comment about the children: "you look just like your mother, just like your father?" We can recognize this because we have an experience, a human experience. Salvation is a human-God experience together. It's not definable; it's just livable.

The Rich Young Ruler did not understand this. He had a legalistic group of rules that he thought he should follow, and he thought he followed them, but he didn't know that the purpose of his life was to become good, and if there's anything in the way of becoming good, you must get rid of it.

This is beautiful news. Maybe it's not easy to get rid of some things, that's not the news I am talking about. But we were born to become good! Isn't that wonderful?

When I was first becoming a believer in some way, I believed in the substitutionary atonement stuff. I thought you asked Jesus in your heart, and Jesus forgives all of your sins, and that's salvation. But I was an

18-year-old young man, and I thought: "Hmm! So this is what salvation is! But I still not a very good guy. I still have thoughts in my heart, and I still get angry at people, and I still have resentment or am lazy; This does not feel like salvation to me! It just feels like some sort of legal fiction!"

Thank God that in a short time, that seemed like forever (when you're 18, everything seems like it moves along slowly) I found the church, and the church said: "*Salvation is not a legal document! Salvation is to become good!*" What a beautiful thing; I can hardly wait till that day when I am just good. I sincerely desire that you also hope for that day. God bless you, and God help us all become good! Priest Seraphim Holland

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## Answers to Questions about The Meeting of the Lord

1. *The "Meeting of the Lord"* commemorates when Jesus was brought to the temple to give sacrifice the 40<sup>th</sup> day after his birth. This is a requirement of Jewish law for the first-born male. It is only described in the Gospel of Luke.

2. *Why did Jesus follow the Jewish law?* As pre-existing God, Jesus is the lawgiver, and as the God-man, He came to fulfill the law completely, so naturally, since He was born in the tribe of Judah, He was subject to Jewish law, and He fulfilled it. He came to enable us to completely obey the law, not the Jewish law, which is only a pale reflection of the Christian law. The Christian law is to love as God loves. He will never ask us to do anything that He has not also done. He requires us to follow the commandments, and He followed the commandments. He requires of his baptism, and He was baptized. He requires of us that we take up our cross, and He took up his cross. He requires of us that we forgive our enemies, and He forgave his enemies.

3. *Why is the Meeting of the Lord February 2?* The historic Meeting of the Lord was in fulfillment of Jewish law, 40 days after Jesus was born. If you do the math, 40 days after December 25 is February 2.

4. *The tradition regarding St. Simeon.* Simeon was the translator of the Septuagint, and when he was translating a part of Isaiah that said: "Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel," he wanted to change the word "virgin" to a word that meant "married woman," but an angel stopped him and informed him that he would remain alive until he saw the fulfillment of this prophecy. He waited for almost 300 years.

5. *When is the song of Simeon used in our prayer services?* The song of Simeon is sung every day at the end of Vespers. It is also a marvelous prayer to add to your evening prayer rule before bed.

6. *The song of Simeon is a prophecy. Of what?* St. Simeon prophesied quite clearly about the ministry of the God-man Jesus Christ while He was still yet an infant. He speaks especially of the reaction of people who encounter Christ and experience His ministry: His mother, the people of Israel, and all of the world for all time. See answer 9.

7. *"Mine eyes have seen thy salvation."* How can we say this part of the Prayer Of Simeon without being liars? To "see the salvation" of the Lord is the same as experiencing God in the heart. This is not knowledge that only our brain understands; it is the soul experiencing God intimately and happens to us in stages, and only with struggle to follow the commandments, repentance, and of course, God's grace. Everything in Christianity is so that we may experience God in our heart, a heart that has no darkness in it - only in the light of God. Therefore, for us to see the salvation of the Lord, we must become like Him, and we must become

perfect in our soul. This is the whole purpose of the church, to bring about this perfection, following our baptism, which enables us to walk (and sometimes, crawl) the path of perfection and succeed. Do not ever let anyone tell you the lie that the Christian life is only believing. It is believing and then acting in accordance with what we believe!

8. *The 40<sup>th</sup>-day sacrifice.* The law required a sacrifice on the 40<sup>th</sup> day after the first-born male's birth to remind the Jews concerning their sin. The 50<sup>th</sup> Psalm talks about us being born in sin, and this is absolutely true. The way human beings are born now is not the way God intended. The entire pregnancy and birth process, and indeed all of human life, has pollutions in it and shedding of blood and pain. For God's people to remain humble, He required this sacrifice.

The Orthodox Church has a practice that harkens back to this Jewish law. Of course, we no longer make a sacrifice because Jesus Christ is the final sacrifice. However, the process of birth and the recovery from it vividly shows that we are still subject to corruption. Therefore, a woman stays away from church for 40 days after her birth, and then prayers are said when she comes to the temple. This is not because we think of pregnancy or childbirth as sinful, but they are not optimal. They are not what God planned originally.

9. *Simeon's prophesies.* "*And Simeon blessed them, and said unto Mary his mother, (1a) Behold, this child is set for the fall and rising again of many in Israel; and (1b) for a sign which shall be spoken against;*

Jesus Christ was a controversial figure in His day and still is. Some speak for Him, and some speak against Him. There are those that follow Him and those that hate Him, or act like they want to follow Him but distort His teachings. Those that follow Him will rise, and those that hate Him or preach heresies about Him will fall.

(2) *(Yea, a sword shall pierce through thy own soul also,)*

The most holy Mother of God bore Jesus Christ without travail. This is a dogma of our faith. Normally childbirth is with pain. Mary's pain was later when she saw her child on the cross, and the sword of sorrow pierced her heart.

(3) *that the thoughts of many hearts may be revealed.*" (Luke 2:34-35)

There is no in-between state regarding Jesus Christ. A person follows Him or resists Him. God will reveal at the judgment those who have been followers of Christ and struggled in this life. All these will "ever be with the Lord." (1 Thess 4:17) Those who hated Christ will be shown to be who they are. There will be no spin or false words. Everything will be evidence in the judgment ("for there is nothing covered, that shall not be revealed; and

hid, that shall not be known.” *Mat 10:26*) This may be frightening to us, but it will be more frightening to sinners who do not repent. What should we do? The answer is obvious. We should struggle to live the Christian life with the grace of God helping us so that when all things are revealed, it will also be revealed that the Lord says to us: “well done, good and faithful servant.”

10. *What did Luke leave out?* The Apostle Luke is very exact in describing the Meeting of the Lord; then he immediately wrote that the holy family was living in Nazareth. He leaves out the flight into Egypt that occurred after the Meeting of the Lord. This could be because he was emphasizing different things or telling the story from accounts he had been given, probably by the mother of God, and since he was not a first-hand witness, he was not comprehensive.

11. *“And he came by the Spirit”* A careful reading of the New Testament shows that the experience of the apostles and the early Christians is wholly different than us. Many sins and distractions weigh us down, and one could even say that we walk about blindly. We search for the will of God, and sometimes we find it, or perhaps other times we hope we have found it, but we are not absolutely sure. The apostles and disciples of the Lord were absolutely sure because they did things “by the Spirit.” This is an objective reality that we can barely even begin to understand. We can talk about it, but very few will experience it. It absolutely has been experienced by holy men and women throughout all of church history.

If we do not have this experience, we should understand that this is not optimum Christian living. We must lack it because of our sins. There is noise in our hearts, and we must get rid of this noise. That is why there is the ascetical life, my friends! That is why you should fast, even in prison. That is why you should be doing prostrations and saying the Jesus prayer for extended periods. This is why you should be reading the Psalms regularly and reading the gospel with prayerful intention. If you have the lives of the saints, you should read them daily.

If you lack some resources because of your environment, such as being in prison, you must adapt and overcome! Live your life ascetically and with expectation. If you have sins, especially frequent ones and ones of the flesh, and don’t give yourself any excuses about them. Struggle against them, confess them, do prostrations because of them and fast because of them. We were born to be led by the Spirit. This is not just a concept, but it is an actual reality.

Here are some examples from the Scriptures, which describe a person led by the Spirit and describe the various instances where the Spirit led Christians.

**Instruction:** For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. *Romans 8:14*

But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you. *John 14:26*

When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth, for he will not speak on his own authority, but whatever he hears he will speak, and he will declare to you the things that are to come. *John 16:13*

But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. *Galatians 5:16*

Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness. For we do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words. *Romans 8:26*

But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law. *Galatians 5:18*

**Examples:** Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. *Matthew 4:1*

Then the Spirit said to Philip, “Go up and join this chariot.” *Acts 8:29*

While Peter was reflecting on the vision, the Spirit said to him, “Behold, three men are looking for you. But get up, go downstairs and accompany them without misgivings, for I have sent them Myself.” *Acts 10:19-20*

The Spirit told me to go with them without misgivings. These six brethren also went with me and we entered the man’s house. *Acts 11:12*

While they were ministering to the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, “Set apart for Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.” *Acts 13:2*

So, being sent out by the Holy Spirit, they went down to Seleucia and from there they sailed to Cyprus. *Acts 13:4*

“For it seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us to lay upon you no greater burden than these essentials: *Acts 15:28*

They passed through the Phrygian and Galatian region, having been forbidden by the Holy Spirit to speak the word in Asia; and after they came to Mysia, they were trying to go into Bithynia, and the Spirit of Jesus did not permit them; *Acts 16:6-7*

Now after these things were finished, Paul purposed in the Spirit to go to Jerusalem after he had passed through Macedonia and Achaia, saying, “After I have been there, I must also see Rome.” *Acts 19:21*

<http://www.orthodox.net/10questions/meeting-of-the-lord.doc>

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<sup>1</sup> *Genesis 1:26-27* And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creepeth upon the earth. (27) So God created man in his *own* image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them.

<sup>2</sup> *Mark 10:21*

<sup>3</sup> *Psalms 106:1* O give thanks unto the Lord, for He is good, for His mercy endureth for ever

<sup>4</sup> *Psalms 81:6* I said: Ye are gods, and all of you the sons of the Most High.

<sup>5</sup> *1Corinthians 13:12*